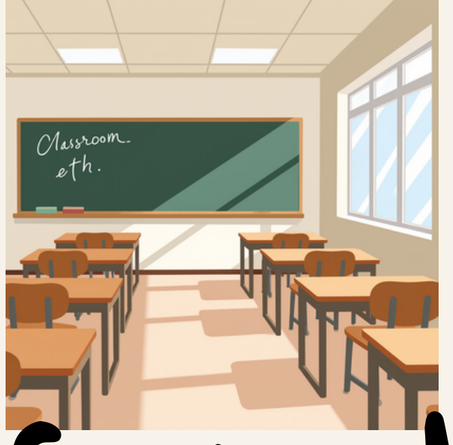

Infographic:

The School To Prison Pipeline

The Pipeline

Exclusionary disciplinary policies, especially zero-tolerance policies, remove students from the instructional environment. This affects the mental and physical aspirations of young children.

Background

Zero-Tolerance Discipline
A policy structure that mandates predetermined, often severe, consequences for specific behaviors regardless of context, intent, or developmental appropriateness.

Pipeline Mechanism
A cumulative process in which repeated suspensions, expulsions, and school-based arrests interrupt academic trajectories and elevate the probability of dropout and later system involvement.
This framework emerged in the 1990s and expanded nationally, shaping disciplinary norms that prioritize punishment over intervention.

Core Data:

Enrollment vs. Punishment Disproportionality

- Public School Enrollment
  - White students: 51%
  - Black students: 16%
- Multiple Suspensions
- White students: 31%
- Black students: 42%

The disproportionality indicates that Black students experience more frequent and severe disciplinary actions despite representing a smaller share of the student population.

Long-Term Educational and Social Impacts

- Increased dropout risk due to chronic disengagement.
- Higher likelihood of juvenile justice involvement.
- Reduced access to advanced coursework, extracurriculars, and leadership opportunities.
- Long-term economic and social consequences for students, families, and communities.

These outcomes demonstrate that disciplinary disparities are not isolated events but components of a broader structural pattern.